



Turkmenistan

Stretching from the Caspian Sea into the central Asian desert, Turkmenistan has had less upheaval than most ex-Soviet states, but President Niyazov was a dictator.



GEOGRAPHY

Low Garagum Desert covers 80% of the country. Mountains on southern border with Iran. Fertile Amu Darya Valley in north.



CLIMATE

Arid desert climate with extreme summer heat, but sub-freezing winter temperatures.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Before Russia annexed the area in 1884, the Turkmen were a largely nomadic tribal people. Today, the tribal unit remains strong, with population clustered around desert oases. Relations with Uzbek and Russian minorities have become tense in recent years due to the "Turkmenization" of government, education, and religion. Political reform since Niyazov's sudden death in 2006 is slowly dismantling the old regime.



THE ECONOMY

State-controlled, though there is some private investment. Natural gas and oil are main resources. Overintensive farming of cotton. Black market.



INSIGHT: President Niyazov created an elaborate personality cult, styling himself as *Turkmenbashi* – "head" of all Turkmen



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Turkmenistan

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Ashgabat

POPULATION: 5.11 million

TOTAL AREA: 188,455 sq. miles
(488,100 sq. km)

DENSITY: 27 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Turkmen*, Uzbek, Russian, Kazakh, Tatar, other

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 87%, Orthodox Christian 11%, other 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Turkmen 77%, Uzbek 9%, Russian 7%, other 5%, Kazakh 2%

GOVERNMENT: One-party state

CURRENCY: Manat = 100 tenge